HOW WELL THE CHILD LEARNS

Learning Trends in Madhya Pradesh, 2012-2018

Class	Percentage of students who could read class II text (story level)	
	2012	2018
Class II	2.7	4
Class III	7	10.4
Class IV	16.9	24.7
Class V	27.5	34.4
Class VI	43	46
Class VII	54.2	53.6
Class VIII	64.4	57.9

Source: Annual State of Education Report (ASER), Pratham

halls for extra-curricular activities like arts, music and dance and space for physical training and games.

How are CM RISE schools different from similar attempts at creating quality schools in the past in MP? A decade ago, the government set up Schools of Excellence, in which students with a certain level of ability and above were taken. However, CM RISE Schools are inclusive and aim to provide quality education irrespective of the child's ability. Before the Schools of Excellence were the Model Schools set up in the 1950s and '60s, which aimed at something similar. "At CM RISE schools, the child is the centre of learning, something we never did in the past. Academics alone is not stressed upon, but wholesome development through promotion of the concepts of RISE—Respect Integrity Strength and Excellence," says Kamleshwar Dayal Shrivastava, principal of the Government School, Barkhedi, now a CM RISE school. Shrivastava claims that attendance was 52 out of 400 high school students the first day the school reopened, which has shot up to 200 now.

MP'S SCHOOLS IN NUMBERS

Total number of schools in MP
1.25 lakh

Total number of govt schools
92,000

Total number of private schools
33,000

Total number of CM RISE schools proposed over ten years
9,200

Total number of CM RISE Schools announced in financial year 2022-23
380

Budget for CM RISE project over the next 10 years
Rs1.53 lakh crores

However, not everyone is a votary of the CM RISE schools concept. "Any policy intervention should be within the framework of the Constitution. No country has been able to achieve universalisation of elementary education without giving equitable education in all schools," says noted educationist Anil Sadgopal, essentially suggesting that 9,200 schools out of 1,00,000 are too few. "By creating schools that have more than others, the government will deny better education to the remaining schools, which is constitutionally unjust," he adds. "More specifically, the CM RISE schools have not been able to shield teachers from election and other government duties that impact teaching." Sadgopal, who was part of the drafting committee for the Right to Education Act, says that MP has had a number of policy interventions in the past, including the "disastrous" Education Guarantee Scheme (EGS), which led to the recruitment of low quality staff. "Many state governments tried addressing issues of quality but often financial support is withdrawn and the schools die a natural death," he says.

Interestingly, though the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and its affiliates are often accused of trying to 'saffronise' the education sector, the CM RISE schools have not run into political controversy. In fact, Opposition Congress MLAs want more schools in their constituencies. "The schools will follow the curriculum of the NEP 2020 approved by the Union government," says an official. Indeed, adherence to NEP 2020 seems to be a reason why the Sangh has no issues with CM RISE schools, except a demand to introduce yoga.

The CM RISE schools face immediate and long term challenges. For one, creation of infrastructure is taking time. Secondly, finding committed teachers is a huge challenge. "Managing expectations is a challenge as these schools set out to achieve what has not been done elsewhere," says Shiladitya Ghosh of People India, a voluntary agency working on the CM RISE project.

The task is gargantuan, but if successful, the CM RISE schools would accomplish the near impossible—providing quality education to those who cannot afford it. ■